

## HOSPITALITY BUILT AMERICA'S ROADS

## THE 8-MILE RULE: HOW TAVERNS CREATED AMERICA

*Before the railroad, before the automobile, and before the highway system, America was stitched together by a network of taverns. The space didn't follow the road. The road followed the space.*

Massachusetts legislators required inns to be placed at intervals **"a day's horseback journey apart"** — roughly every 8 miles — specifically because wayfarers without a tavern were compelled to request shelter from private citizens. As American Heritage notes, *"legislators of Puritan times had decidedly mixed feelings about alcohol, [but] they sanctioned taverns in order to provide wayfarers with shelter and sustenance."*<sup>[2]</sup> Janet

Fortran, American Heritage, Vol. 54 Issue 3

The result was a national hospitality network built before the nation itself. Star Tavern's research on the Great Wagon Trail — the trail running from Pennsylvania through the Appalachian Valley to Georgia — describes thousands of families traveling this path in search of opportunity, with **taverns providing the only reliable food and shelter along the way.**<sup>[1]</sup> startavern.net

## THE TOWN-BUILDING FORMULA

In new settlements, the sequence of construction plans showed that taverns we're a priority. In 1755, of the seven or eight houses in Salisbury, North Carolina, **four were taverns or inns.** One local clergyman reportedly lamented that the tavern was faring far better than the church in the competition for men's souls.<sup>[2]</sup> American Heritage, Vol. 54 Issue 3

## THE 8-MILE RULE — STAGECOACH ROUTE LOGIC

- 0 miles** — Town center, starting point
- 8 miles** — First tavern. Horses watered, travelers fed, news exchanged.
- 16 miles** — Second tavern. Midday stop. Commerce conducted. Letters posted.
- 24 miles** — Third tavern. Overnight lodging. One full day's journey completed.

Source: American Heritage Vol. 54 Issue 3; Star Tavern, startavern.net

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**Buildings in 1755 Salisbury, NC were taverns or inns**

American Heritage, Vol. 54 Issue 3 — Janet Fortran

## 1635

**First commercial brewery licensed in America — driven by tavern demand**

Massachusetts Bay Colony licensed Captain Robert Sedgwick as first "common brewer" — American Heritage

Sources: Janet Fortran, American Heritage Vol. 54 Issue 3; Star Tavern, startavern.net